

The Complete Financial Guide for Young Couples

doesn't necessarily mean the flashiest brands or the highest-cost clothes. More often it means selecting the best quality fabric from an established manufacturer.

One source that I rely on regularly is *Consumer Reports* magazine, which you'll find at most local libraries. *Consumer Reports* evaluates all types of products, including clothing, for quality, price, and durability.

Another resource many families have rediscovered in recent years is nearly-new stores. In well-managed stores, the merchandise is top quality and in excellent shape. These stores are particularly useful when it comes to filling unique clothing needs, such as maternity clothes, wedding apparel, and children's items.

A friend of ours recently located a wedding dress at a nearly-new store that would have sold retail for over \$500. She paid \$15 for it and after dry-cleaning, the gown was as good as new. She reduced the cost of her daughter's wedding by \$485.

However, not every good buy is a great buy. Another friend, whose wife often shops nearly-new stores, told me about the terrific suits she found him. They were just his size, in perfect shape, and a top-quality brand. When she saw them for \$7 apiece, she snapped up six of them. But when her husband took them off the hangers, he found they had no backs in them. Later he learned they were display suits used by a local undertaker to show bodies at his funeral home. He kept threatening to wear one to church to show his friends how "frugal" his wife really was. Then one day they all mysteriously disappeared.

As you consider your family's clothing budget, ask yourself these questions: (1) does it really matter whether you have all of the latest styles? (2) do your purchases reflect good quality or ego? (3) do you buy clothes to satisfy family needs or to satisfy whims and indulgences?

CATEGORY 7: MEDICAL AND DENTAL EXPENSES

Approximately 5 percent of your net spendable income can be allocated to medical and dental expenses. There is a great